

The Exile's Spear at the Edge of the World

A tale of The Sundering of Avelorn

*High Fantasy · Epic, urgent, morally complex — heroism is
possible but costly*

as played by Ming

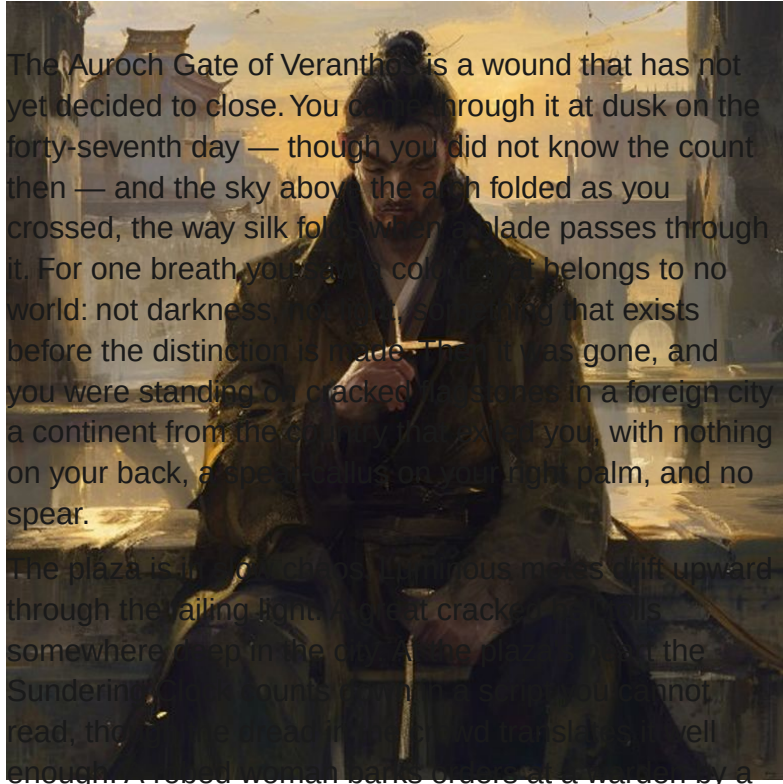
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Chapter 1

The Door Was Always Yours



The Auroch Gate of Veranthor is a wound that has not yet decided to close. You cross through it at dusk on the forty-seventh day — though you did not know the count then — and the sky above the arch folded as you crossed, the way silk folds when a blade passes through it. For one breath you were colorless, not belongs to no world: not darkness, not light, something that exists before the distinction is made. Then it was gone, and you were standing on cracked flagstones in a foreign city, a continent from the one you had exited you, with nothing on your back, a speck of callus on your right palm, and no spear.

The plaza is lit by torches as luminous moths drift upward through the veiling fog. In the great cracked archway, somewhere deep in the city, the plaza where the Sundering took counts down the street you cannot read, though the dread in the air and the slaves sell well enough. A veiled woman barks orders at a warder by a hatch in the ground. A scarred northern woman watches you across the stones. And a courier boy, perhaps ten years old, has just pressed a sealed note into your hand and stepped back to see what your face will do.

The note is warm from his palm. The wax seal bears a stylized eye, bisected by a single vertical line.

» *Read the sealed note in your hand*

You break the wax with your thumbnail. The seal comes apart cleanly — a stylized eye bisected by a vertical line, a symbol you file away without recognition. The note inside is written in trade-tongue, the hand precise and unhurried, as though composed somewhere quiet while the world outside burned:

'Ming of Zhennian. The Sundering Clock in the Veranthos plaza reads forty-seven days. You have arrived on the forty-seventh. I do not think that is coincidence. I do not think you do either.

I know why you were exiled. I know what you carried out of Zhennian that you were not permitted to carry. I do not intend to use this knowledge against you — I intend to use you. There is a distinction, and I would ask you to hold it carefully.

Come to the Lamplighter's Arch on Coppervane Street before the second bell tonight. Come alone. Burn this when you have finished reading.

The Wellspring will not wait for your suspicion to subside.'

No signature. No seal-name. Nothing.

The courier boy — Dav Soot — is still crouched at your knee, affecting enormous interest in a crack in the cobblestones. He is waiting to see what your face does. It does nothing, because you were trained for exactly this: the moment when a stranger announces they know your wound. Across the plaza, Archmagister Thessaly

Vorn has won her argument with the warden and is descending through the hatch, robes trailing chalk-dust. The Thornwood woman — Orrath — has moved perhaps six steps closer to you while your eyes were on the page. She did not try to hide it. That itself is a message.

» Thank the boy and wave him off, then turn to the Thornwood woman to read her intention

You fold the note once, twice, and tuck it into your sash — the instruction to burn it noted and, for now, deferred. Information destroyed is information surrendered, and you have surrendered enough. To the boy you say *xièxie* in the clipped Zhennian fashion, the syllables landing flat against the trade-tongue noise of the plaza. He blinks. He does not understand the word, but the dismissal in the gesture is a language anyone who has ever been small and useful understands immediately. Dav Soot stands, rubs his knee, and affects the direction of the fountain as though that was always his destination. He does not go far. You notice this. You let him think you don't.

» Turn to face the Thornwood woman and let her speak first

You turn to face the Thornwood woman without closing the distance. The six extra steps she took were deliberate, and meeting that deliberateness with a rush would be exactly wrong. You plant your feet at shoulder width — not a fighting stance, something earlier than a fighting stance — and simply look at her the way she

has been looking at you. Openly. Accounting.

She is older than she seemed from across the plaza. The clan-scars on her jaw are old work, layered over by sun and wind into a kind of topography. The bones threaded into her hair click faintly as she tilts her head. Her eyes are the pale grey of overcast sky, and they move across you with professional thoroughness — your hands, your shoulders, the angle of your hips, the way the spear-callus sits on your right palm. The inventory of a person who decides quickly whether strangers are threats or tools.

She speaks first. Trade-tongue, but shaped by a northern accent that rounds the vowels like river stones: 'You fell with the others when the sky bent. You stood before they did.' A pause that is not uncomfortable — more like punctuation. 'You are not Avelornian. You are not Conclave. You did not look at the arch with fear.' She lets that sit. Then: 'What did you see, on the other side, when it opened?'

» Answer honestly — describe the nameless colour I saw when the sky folded

You consider lying. The calculation takes less than a breath and comes up empty — this woman has spent her life reading terrain, and a face is terrain. You say, in trade-tongue, carefully: 'A colour. Not one that belongs here. Not darkness, not light. Something that exists before the distinction is made.' You watch her face for the reaction most people give — the polite blankness that means they are filing you under eccentric. It does

not come. Instead something tightens at the corner of her eye. Recognition, or the cousin of it. 'It has a name in our tongue,' she says, and the bones in her hair click as she looks briefly skyward, as though checking whether the scar might reopen. 'We call it *voreth*. The colour of a thing before it decides what it is. The shamans say the Wellspring bled *voreth* on the day it was first bound — that the Covenant forced it to choose a shape, and it has been grieving the other shapes ever since.' She brings her gaze back down to you. The pale eyes are steady, and for the first time something in them is not purely tactical. 'You are the third person I have met outside the Thornwood who has seen it. The first two were Conclave mages.' A beat. 'They are both dead now. The Wellspring reached back into them through the colour, the shamans say, to reclaim what was taken.' She does not say this as a threat. She says it the way a soldier reports casualties: cleanly, because the truth is less dangerous than the surprise.

» Keep my own counsel: thank her for the warning, disengage, and observe from a distance

You incline your head — a slow, deliberate bow, shallow enough to be courtesy rather than deference, deep enough to be genuine. In Zhennian it means: *I have heard you, and I will not waste what you gave me.* Whether she reads any of that in the angle is uncertain, but Orrath accepts it without comment, which suggests she understands the grammar of restraint. 'Walk carefully,' she says, simply. Not a farewell. A recommendation. You turn and move away through the

thinning crowd before she can add anything that might require a response you are not yet ready to give. You find your position against the base of an unbroken column, twenty paces from the ruined arch, angled so that the whole plaza opens before you. Old habit: stone at your back, sightlines clear, two exits within a sprint. The luminous motes drift upward through the failing light, thicker now than minutes ago. A city warden has given up trying to disperse them and simply watches them rise, hands at his sides, in the posture of a man whose training did not cover this. Orrath has not moved toward you. She has returned her attention to the arch — but once, briefly, her eyes find your column with the same calm precision she might use to mark a tree in unfamiliar forest. She knows exactly where you are. The courier boy, Dav Soot, is crouched near the fountain with a heel of bread he produced from nowhere, performing childhood so thoroughly that only the stillness of his ears betrays him; he is listening in a radius of ten feet, cataloguing. Across the plaza, Archmagister Thessaly Vorn has emerged again from the hatch beneath the gate and stands now in the middle of the plaza with a small leather-bound instrument pressed to the cracked capstone. Her mouth is set. Whatever the instrument tells her, she does not like it.

» Leave the plaza and scout the route to Lamplighter's Arch before nightfall

You push off the column and enter the crowd at a walker's pace — not hurrying, because hurry is a flag. The plaza empties into the Coppervane district through

a narrow throat of a street called the Stitchway, and you take it, letting the press of evening foot traffic absorb you the way river water absorbs a stone. The city speaks to you as you move. Veranthos is beautiful in the way of things that know they are dying — spired facades still gilded, ley-lanterns humming along the eaves in amber chains, but every third lamp stuttering, and twice in two blocks the cobblestones beneath your feet exhale a faint warmth as though a fire burns just below the surface. A fault-line, buried but present. You mark it. You mark the guard-post at the Stitchway's mouth — two wardens in Throne livery, one attentive, one watching the sky with the hollow expression of a man rationing his fear — and you mark the shrine of the First Archmages at the district crossroads, where someone has left fresh flowers and a broken ward-stone side by side, offering and accusation together. Lamplighter's Arch is easy to find. It stands at the southern end of Coppervane Street proper — a triumphal arch from some older war, the stone carved with flame-motifs now blackened by the ley-lanterns hung beneath it in dense clusters, a dozen extinguished among them. From the arch you can count: two approach routes from the north, one alley to the east narrow enough to make pursuit ugly, a cooper's workshop across the street with a hayloft window overlooking the meeting point at roughly forty degrees elevation. That window could be a problem. The arch itself has a deep alcove on its western face — shadow even at noon, a natural place to put a sword or a conversation you want no one to overhear. Someone

chose this location with care. You spend eight minutes on the scout, moving in a wide spiral, cataloguing. You find no watchers you can name. That is not the same as finding none.

» *Find a smith or stall — I arrived with nothing, and even a knife changes the arithmetic*

You have two hours before second bell, and an empty hand changes every calculation you made at Lamplighter's Arch. Coppervane is a merchant district — there should be ironwork within three streets in any direction. You turn east off the main road, following the smell of coal-smoke and the particular clang of a hammer finding a cold join rather than a hot one: a smith winding down for the evening, not starting up. The first forge you find is shuttered, chain across the door, a notice in Avelornian script you can read only poorly. The second is open but the smith — a broad woman with red forearms and no patience — takes one look at your foreign face and the empty purse you produce and turns back to her cooling rack without a word. The third is not a smith at all but a tinker's cart wedged in an alley mouth, the tinker himself already loading unsold stock into canvas bags with the focused economy of a man who lost money today and intends to lose no more time. You scan the cart. Pot-menders, lamp-hooks, a broken pruning blade, small agricultural tools. Nothing you would trust your life to. You try three words of trade-tongue — knife, sell, price — and the tinker looks at your empty hands and empty purse and the foreign cut of your coat and makes the same calculation the smith

made. He shakes his head before you finish the sentence. The light is going amber at the rooftop level. You have walked in a narrowing circle and come back to Coppervane Street with nothing changed except the hour, which has changed against you. The arch is visible from here, its extinguished lanterns dark against the dusk. Second bell is closer than you would like. You are exactly as empty-handed as when you started.

» I don't need a weapon for this meeting; I have nothing to lose. Find a quiet corner near the arch and meditate

You find the corner without searching for it — a recess between a chandler's shuttered frontage and the blank stone shoulder of the arch itself, deep enough to swallow you, angled so that the western alcove and the hayloft window both sit within your peripheral field. The laugh you allow yourself is a quiet thing, barely breath. You have attended meetings with nothing before. You once walked into the exam of the Seventh Form with a broken wrist and emerged with the highest mark of your cohort. The empty hands are familiar. They are, in a sense, the only honest introduction you have left to make. You fold your legs beneath you, spine long, and let the city's noise become texture rather than information. The warm fault-line pulse beneath the cobblestones rises through your sitting bones in a slow, irregular rhythm — not a heartbeat, something older and less certain than a heartbeat. The luminous motes you first saw at the Auroch Gate are here too, sparse but present, drifting at knee-height through the dusk like embers from a fire you cannot locate. One passes

through the edge of your hand. You feel nothing. Or almost nothing. A faint resonance, low and nameless, in the centre of your sternum — the place where the Crane-in-Storm form tells you to anchor your breath. You note it. You do not pursue it. The second bell begins to ring somewhere deeper in the city. It is a cracked sound — the same bell you heard on arrival, still carrying its wound. In the western alcove of Lamplighter's Arch, the shadows shift. Someone has been there for some time. They waited for the bell before they moved, and that tells you something about how they prefer the arithmetic of meetings: let the other person wonder. You open your eyes fully and rise in a single unhurried motion, the way water levels itself. Empty hands at your sides. You cross the six paces to the arch in silence.

» Say nothing and let them begin — read every detail of their opening move

The alcove gives her up slowly. She is not tall — you register that first, because the note had the authority of height and she does not have it. What she has instead is stillness, the particular stillness of someone who has learned to make a room forget they are in it. She is perhaps fifty, perhaps older, Avelornian by her cheekbones and the silver threadwork at her collar, which is Conclave-adjacent but not Conclave — the weave is close, the colour wrong, a deep grey where the Arcane College wears blue. Her hair is white and pinned without vanity. Her hands rest at her sides, open, visible. She made sure you would see that. The bisected-eye mark is embroidered, small and precise, on her left cuff.

She holds the silence for three full breaths after you stop moving. Letting you look. Letting you measure. When she speaks, it is in trade-tongue, but her Zhennian is there underneath the words like bedrock under soil: 'You did not burn the note.' She does not sound disappointed. She sounds like she knew. 'My name is Serevaine. I have no title I currently acknowledge. I knew your teacher before he was your teacher, which is a longer story than we have standing in an archway.' She takes one step forward into the last of the dusk light — deliberate, un-aggressive, offering her face to your read. 'I need to know one thing before I tell you anything useful. The mote. Near the second column from the fountain, during your meditation. What did you feel when it passed through you?' Her voice does not change register asking it. But her hands, still open at her sides, have gone very still.

» Tell her exactly what I felt — the single note below sound, lodged at the sternum, a door opening

You let the silence run one breath longer than is comfortable — not to be difficult, but because the words for this do not exist in trade-tongue and you are building them from what you have. When you speak, your voice is low and unhurried, the same register you use to explain a technique to a student who has not yet earned the full explanation. 'A single note. Below sound — felt rather than heard. It lived here' — your right hand lifts and presses two fingers flat against your sternum, between the third and fourth rib, exactly where the Crane-in-Storm form places the root of the breath-

column — 'and it did not arrive. It was already there. The mote passed through and it recognised something. Or something in me recognised the mote. I cannot tell you which.' You lower your hand. 'It did not feel like intrusion. It felt like a door opening that I did not know was a door. And it closed again without asking my preference.' You hold her gaze steadily. 'I have felt that precise location once before. The morning my teacher handed me something I was not permitted to carry out of Zhennian, and told me I would be exiled before nightfall. He pressed two fingers here, the same way, and said nothing. I did not understand it then.' You stop. You have told her exactly what she asked and not one word beyond it. The space after the words is hers now. Her face has done something — not surprise, which would be dishonest, but a kind of careful settling, the way a navigator who has been estimating by the stars suddenly gets a fixed landmark. Her open hands at her sides have not moved. But her composure has shifted by some small, legible degree inward, toward something that in another person might be relief.

» *"You said you knew him." Hold the silence and make the next move hers to earn*

The words land softly, but they land like a weight placed on a scale. *You said you knew him.* Not a question. Not an accusation. A boundary, drawn with a single sentence, precisely where she pressed. Serevaine's composure does not crack. But something behind it shifts — she was expecting deflection, or demand, or fear. She was not expecting the counter-offered silence

of someone who has decided the next move is hers to earn. Her pale eyes move once to your hands, which have not reached for anything because there is nothing to reach for, but which have settled differently at your sides — weight forward, not back, the Crane-in-Storm root planted in the cobblestone through your soles. She reads it accurately. She does not step back. To her credit. 'I knew him as Liang Sorveth,' she says. 'Which is not the name he gave you, I think, and not the name the Zhennian court has on any record.' She watches the name land. 'He came to Avelorn seventeen years ago carrying a fragment of something he should not have been able to carry — something that should have been sealed here, beneath the Auric Mountains, for another thousand years. He said he had borrowed it.' The faint emphasis on **borrowed** implies a history with the word. 'He went back east. He marked a student and exiled him toward a cracking world and a meeting at second bell, which means he knew both were coming.' She tilts her head, the smallest increment. 'I am not your enemy tonight, Ming. But I am asking: what did he give you to carry? Not what you think it is. What it actually is — because your body already knows, even if your mind has not caught it yet.'

» *Give her something real and watch where it lands — the room he built inside me*

You hold the preparation a moment longer — the weight-forward stance, the open calculation — and then you release it. Not because the threat has passed. Because she has already told you more than she meant to and

the fastest way to the rest is to give her something real and watch where it lands. 'I carried nothing I could name,' you say. 'Nothing with shape or weight. When my teacher pressed his fingers here' — the same two-finger gesture against the sternum, a habit already — 'I felt a warmth that stayed. For seventeen days after, I dreamed in a colour I had no word for. Then it faded, and I decided I had imagined it. I decided the exile itself was the punishment, and the warmth was grief, and the colour was what grief looks like from the inside.' A pause, thin as a blade. 'Three hours ago I walked through the Auroch Gate and the sky folded and I saw the colour again. Not grief. Not imagined. And when the mote touched me in meditation, it found the warmth still there — not faded. Waiting.' You watch her face with the specific attention you once used to read the angle of a spear before it moved. 'He did not give me an object. He gave me a location. He built a room inside my body and put something in it and bricked the door and sent me to the one city in the world where the wall between rooms is breaking.' The words cost something to say aloud. The shame behind the sternum shifts — not smaller, but different in shape, because exile-as-engineering is a different wound than exile-as-failure. 'I do not know what I am carrying. But I think you do. And I think your face just confirmed it.' Serevaine's composure does not shatter. But it moves. Her open hands rise — not defensively, not threateningly — and she presses her own fingertips briefly to her sternum, an involuntary mirror of your gesture, and then catches herself doing it

and lowers them with the deliberate care of someone reclaiming a tell. The bisected-eye mark on her cuff catches the last dusk-light. When she speaks, her voice is half a degree quieter than it has been, which on a woman of this stillness is the equivalent of shouting. 'He called it a Shard of Prior Covenant,' she says. 'Not a fragment of the Wellspring. Older than that. A piece of what the Wellspring was bound from.' Her eyes hold yours. 'The Sealers believe they need four cardinal shrine-components to re-bind the Wellspring. They are wrong. They need five. The fifth is not at a shrine.' She lets the silence complete the sentence. 'Your teacher was supposed to return it seventeen years ago. He did not. He chose you instead, which means he believed you would reach this city at this exact moment and that the Sundering Clock would have forty-seven days remaining when you did.' A breath. 'He also believed you would be difficult to convince. He asked me to tell you one thing, if all else failed.' Her composure is fully back now, settled like armour. 'He said to tell you: the door was always yours. He only built the frame.'

» *Tell her the truth plainly: I was banished because I won the fight I should not win*

The words come out clean and level, the way truth does when it has been carried a long time and finally set down. *I was banished because I won the fight I shouldn't win.* No bitterness in it. No performance. Just the stone behind the sternum, named aloud for the first time in a foreign city to a foreign woman who claims to have been waiting seventeen years for exactly this

moment. Serevaine is quiet for longer than she has been quiet before. The dusk has finished its work — the arch lanterns that still function have come on around you, amber and guttering, and in their light her face is readable in a way that full daylight might have concealed. She is not calculating. She is, for the first time, simply listening. When she speaks, her voice carries no persuasion in it. That absence is itself a kind of respect. 'I know,' she says. 'He told me. A prodigy who broke the form that was not supposed to be broken, beat the master who was not supposed to be beatable, and was removed from the board before anyone had to decide what he meant.' A pause. 'The Zhennian court exiled you. Liang Sorveth handed you a burning brand to carry across a continent and pointed you at a cracking world. Those are also fights you did not choose.' She lets that sit. 'But Ming.' Her voice drops further, not softer — more precise, the way a blade gets when it is being used for its actual purpose. 'The Shard in your sternum does not care what you were banished for. The Wellspring does not care whether you came here willingly. The forty-seven days will expire regardless of your concern.' She tilts her head, and something almost human crosses her face — not pity, but acknowledgment, the recognition of one exiled thing naming another. 'You said you have nothing to lose. I am telling you that is not true anymore. You walked through the Auroch Gate carrying the only piece that can prevent a rupture that will unmake every kingdom, every exile, and every fight you ever won or lost. The door was

always yours.' She exhales slowly. 'The question is not whether this is your concern. The question is what you want to do with a concern you were given without your consent — and whether the man who gave it to you deserves an answer.'

» Ask the arithmetic: what do you want from me, and what do you get?

The question cuts through everything she has built — the careful framing, the patience, the teacher's last words deployed like a key. You ask it the way you would ask the range of a weapon before deciding whether to close distance: not hostility, not warmth. Arithmetic.

What do you want from me. What do you get.

Serevaine does not look away. She does not reach for composure because she has not lost it, but something behind her eyes makes a decision, and the decision is honesty, and honesty costs her something visible. 'I want the Shard delivered intact to the fifth-point of the re-binding ritual beneath the Auric Mountains before the Sundering Clock expires,' she says. 'That is the simple part.' She takes one slow breath. 'What I get — what any of us get — is a world that continues to exist in a form recognisable to the people currently living in it. That is not a small thing, but I understand it is also not yours.' Her hands come together at her waist, not clasped — fingers resting against fingers, the gesture of a person holding themselves to precision. 'I should tell you the rest.' The quality of the silence shifts. 'The Sealers do not know a fifth component exists. Archmagister Vorn is a careful woman and a genuine believer, but she is

working from an incomplete Covenant-text, and if she attempts the re-binding without the Prior Shard she will fail — the rupture will accelerate rather than seal, and the failure will consume everyone in the ritual chamber.' A pause that has weight in it. 'I have been trying to tell her for three years. She believes I am a Quietist agent. I am not a Quietist agent. I am something older and considerably more inconvenient.' The bisected-eye mark on her cuff catches the amber light. 'As for what the ritual requires of you specifically — the Shard cannot be removed from a living vessel by force. It can only be offered. Willingly. At the site.' She holds your gaze with the steady attention of a woman who has rehearsed this sentence and hates every word of it. 'The texts are ambiguous on whether the vessel survives the offering. I will not lie to you about that. Liang Sorveth did not ask your consent. I am asking it. Those are different things, and I know they are not the same as a guarantee.' She stops. The cracked bell in the city's interior has long since finished its count. The alcove holds the two of you and the amber guttering and the fault-line warmth rising through the stones beneath your feet, patient as an old wound.

» Ask both — is the ambiguity about how the offering works, or what it does to the body? And who wrote the texts?

The question arrives with the precision of a spear-tip finding the gap between plates. Not the fact of possible death — you have lived adjacent to that since the exile — but the architecture of the ambiguity. Whether the

texts are vague about how the offering works, or vague about what it does to the body that offers. Those are different uncertainties. You ask both. And then, because the bisected-eye mark has been sitting in your peripheral attention since she stepped into the light: who wrote them. Serevaine is still for a moment that has a different quality than her previous stillnesses. This one is not composure over calculation. It is composure over something that resembles old grief, and you file that away immediately. 'The method is precise,' she says. 'The Shard must be at the fifth-point of the ritual geometry. The vessel must speak the release — a single phrase in Prior Covenant tongue, which I can teach you. The Wellspring does the rest. There is no knife involved. No extraction. You stand at the centre of something older than the kingdom and you open the door.' Her fingers press flat against her own sternum before she catches them and lowers them, and this time she does not pretend she did not do it. She has stopped pretending. 'The ambiguity is entirely in the outcome. Three texts survive that describe the Prior Covenant. Two were written by the First Archmages themselves — who sealed the Wellspring originally, and who were not vessels. They were theorising. The third text is fragmentary and in a script we spent eleven years partially translating.' A pause with an edge to it. 'That text suggests the vessel and the Shard are not separable in the way the Archmage texts assume. That seventeen years of carrying may have created a correspondence — that the Shard has become partly

Ming-shaped, and Ming has become partly Shard-shaped, and what happens when that geometry is released at the fifth-point is genuinely unknown.' She meets your eyes and does not soften it. 'The Archmage texts say the vessel is emptied and walks away. The third text says the door and the frame cannot be taken apart without consequence to both. I do not know which is correct. I have spent three years trying to find out and I have forty-four days left and you are the only person who can answer the question from the inside.' The amber lantern above the alcove gutters in a draft carrying the faint copper-salt smell of a Fault-scar somewhere upwind. 'As for who wrote the third text.' She reaches into the grey coat and produces something small — a folded paper, old, the creases worn soft — and holds it out without releasing it yet. 'It was found seventeen years ago in the personal effects of a Far-Eastern scholar who came to Avelorn and left again without permission. The Conclave confiscated it. I borrowed it from the Conclave.' The word borrowed carries the same weight it did when she used it of Liang Sorveth, and she knows you hear that. 'Your teacher wrote the third text, Ming. He wrote it here, in this city, before he went back east and built a frame around a door and sent it home inside a student.' She extends the folded paper the remaining distance. 'It is written in your language. I cannot read it. I have been carrying it for seventeen years waiting for someone who could.'

» *Take the paper and read it*

You take the paper from her fingers without hesitation.

That itself is information you give her freely — that you are not afraid of what your teacher wrote, or that you are afraid and have decided it does not matter which. The paper is old in the specific way of things that have been handled often: the folds soft as cloth, the edges worn to a fine chamois smoothness. Someone has held this many times without opening it. You open it. The script is your home language — not the formal court-hand you were taught in the academies, but the personal register your teacher used when he corrected your forms with margin-notes. The characters are smaller than they should be, pressed close, written in the cramped urgency of someone who had very little time and a great deal to say. You read it twice. What Liang Sorveth wrote in this city seventeen years ago is this: the Shard is not a piece of the Wellspring's binding. It is a piece of the Wellspring's memory — a fragment of a will that chose to become the Wellspring, the part that refused to be sealed, which could not be contained in stone and could only survive inside a living body that was itself in exile from where it belonged. He writes that he carried it for eleven years and it changed him in ways he did not consent to and could not undo. He writes that he chose Ming not because Ming was the best student, but because Ming already knew what it was to be something that had refused to stay inside the shape the world assigned it. And then, pressed into the bottom margin in smaller characters, added at the last possible moment: do not let them use you as a key. You are not a key. Find out what the Wellspring wills before you decide whether

to offer anything at all. You lower the paper. You do not look up immediately. You give yourself three full seconds and in those three seconds you are aware that Serevaine has not moved, has not spoken, and has been watching your face with the attention of someone who has waited seventeen years for this particular expression. You look up. Your face has done one thing it does not do: it has gone completely still in the way that is not composure. It is the stillness of a man who has just learned that the worst thing that ever happened to him was also a gift, and that both facts are equally true, and that he does not yet know what to do with either.

» Go to the safehouse she named — the Undyed Cloth on Tanners' Row — and rest

Tanners' Row is exactly what its name promises — low buildings, the ghost of cured hide in the cold air, lanterns spaced far enough apart that the dark between them is full and private. The Undyed Cloth is a narrow place, three storeys, its sign a pale rectangle of unfinished wool. The woman Passa opens the door before you knock, which means Serevaine sent word by a route faster than your walking, and you file that information away in the part of the mind that does not sleep. Passa is broad, grey-haired, and entirely incurious — the particular incuriosity of a professional, which is its own kind of trustworthiness. She hands you a key and points at the stairs without speaking. You are grateful for this more than you expected to be. The room is small and clean. A basin, a pitcher of water still faintly warm, a bed with a quilt the colour of undyed wool, a single candle.

You eat the bread and hard cheese left on the table beside the basin and you do not think about the paper or the sternum or the forty-seven days. You eat because the body that carries the Shard is still a body, and it walked a long way today through a folded sky, and it is owed bread and cheese and the absence of consequence for a few hours. The food is plain and adequate and you finish all of it. You sleep. And in the sleep — not immediately, not in the shallow water near the surface, but deep in, where discipline does not reach — the colour comes again. Voreth. Not a dream exactly. More like the inside of the door, lit from the other side. It does not speak. It does not reach. It is simply present the way the warmth in your sternum is present: already there, patient, waiting to find out what you will decide to make of it. You sleep through it without waking. That itself is something. The old Ming would have woken. The exile carrying a splinter of a god's refusal sleeps through the colour of a thing before it decides what it is, and in the morning the candle has burned to nothing and the light coming through the shutter-crack is the pale grey of an hour before the city remembers it is a city.

» In the morning, ask Passa about the Far-Eastern scholar who stayed here years ago

You wash your face in the basin's cold water, dress, and fold Liang Sorveth's paper back into your inner pocket with the deliberate care of a man filing a weapon he is not yet ready to use. Then you go downstairs. Passa is already in the narrow kitchen, moving between hearth and table with the economy of someone who has

opened this house every morning for a very long time. She sets a bowl of porridge in front of you without being asked and pours something hot and dark that is not tea but functions as tea, and you eat half of it before you ask. 'Seventeen years ago,' you say, in the careful Avelornian you have been building since the border. 'A Far-Eastern scholar. He would have stayed somewhere like this. He would have been quiet and inconvenient in equal measure.' You pause. 'He went by at least two names.' Passa refills her own cup and sits across from you, which she did not do last night, and looks at you with the particular attention of a woman deciding how much something is worth. 'Seventeen years is a long time,' she says. 'I have been running this house for twenty-three.' She wraps both hands around her cup. 'There was a man. Eastern eyes, like yours, but older — maybe sixty when I knew him, maybe more. He stayed four months, which is unusual. Paid in advance, which is less unusual. Wrote constantly, all hours. The ink stains on the desk in room four are his — I stopped trying to sand them out.' A pause. 'He left one morning without warning, which they do. But he left something behind. Not forgot — left deliberately, propped against the pillow like a decision.' She gets up, opens the small locked box on the shelf above the hearth that you clocked last night and filed away as her business, and sets a small flat object on the table between the bowls. It is a carved token — dark wood, the size of a thumb — incised with a single character in your home script. Not a word. A name-mark. His. 'I kept it because it felt wrong to throw it

away,' Passa says. 'I kept it because seventeen years ago a woman with a bisected-eye mark on her cuff came by asking about him the week after he left, and she looked at it and said: hold onto that. Someone will come for it eventually.' She meets your eyes across the table with perfect uncuriosity. 'I imagine that is you.'

» *Pick up the name-token and ask Passa what he was like in those four months*

You pick up the name-token and hold it without closing your fist around it — the same way you hold a weapon you are not yet sure is yours. The carved character is his, unmistakably: the particular stroke-weight he used when signing corrections, the small hook at the tail that was an idiosyncrasy of his province. You set it beside the bowl and look at Passa. 'What was he like,' you say. 'In the four months. His habits. Whether he had visitors. Whether he seemed afraid.' Passa drinks from her cup and considers this with the same unhurried attention she has given everything so far — the attention of a woman who has housed a great many people and learned that the ones worth remembering are rarely the ones who announce themselves. 'Disciplined,' she says first. 'Up before the house, asleep after it. He ate what was given and never complained and never left food unfinished, which I appreciate. He moved quietly — not like a man hiding, more like a man who had decided noise was a waste.' She pauses. 'He meditated in the courtyard each morning. Not praying — something more physical. Breathing work, and a stillness that was not stillness. His hands moved sometimes, very slightly, as if he was

practising something too small to see.' She glances at your hands around the bowl without making a point of it. 'He had one visitor. Twice. A young Avelornian — Conclave robes but worn like he was embarrassed by them, maybe thirty years old at the time. They spoke in the courtyard in low voices and the second time the visitor left quickly and did not come back.' 'The fear,' she says, and pauses again, deciding something. 'Not afraid of people. He watched the sky — the direction of the Auric Mountains specifically, every evening, the way a sailor watches weather. Three weeks before he left, he stopped sleeping through the night. I heard him moving in room four. I heard the pen. He was writing faster at the end than at the beginning.' She wraps both hands around her cup again. 'The morning he left he came down early and ate everything on the table — everything, mine included, which he had never done — and he looked at me the way people look at a place they know they will not see again. He said: you will know who to give it to because they will not ask what it is worth.' She meets your eyes. 'You did not ask.'

» *Ask to see the room he stayed in — room four*

Passa looks at you across the table with the expression of a woman who has already decided the answer and is simply waiting for the question to finish arriving. She stands without ceremony, picks up a candle from the shelf — the morning light doesn't reach the upper floors yet — and tilts her head toward the stairs. She does not ask why. Room four is the second door on the left. It is the same dimensions as yours, the same quilt, the same

shutter-crack letting in the grey early light. But the desk is different. It is an old piece, the wood dark with age, and the surface has been sanded and resanded over many years in the way of something a careful person keeps trying to make clean. The stains remain. Not a spill — not the careless pooling of an overturned inkstone. These are the stains of sustained, pressured writing: the fine spray that comes from a brush moved fast, the heavier blot where a hand stopped mid-stroke and held, the long thin trail of a character begun and abandoned. You recognise the pattern of the abandoned character. It is the same one on the name-token in your pocket. He was practising writing his own name and stopped. You stand at the desk and look at it for a moment that is longer than it should be. Passa stands in the doorway with the candle, watching you with the patient attention she has given everything this morning. She does not fill the silence. The stains are seventeen years old and they still smell, very faintly, of ink and something else — the mineral-cold scent that clings to a place near a Fault-scar. Faint, old, almost not there. But you know it now. Your sternum knows it. He was working here when the Wellspring began to bleed, or perhaps he was working here and the Wellspring began to bleed in response, and you do not yet know which direction the causation runs.

» Press two fingers to the oldest ink-stain and open to the Shard

You press two fingers to the desk. Not the sternum gesture — a different thing, deliberate: fingertips flat

against the oldest ink-stain, the heaviest one, where he held the brush too long and let the ink pool. The wood is cold and smooth and for a moment there is nothing except the faint mineral smell and the grey light through the shutter-crack and Passa breathing quietly in the doorway. Then: not warmth. Not the clean resonance you felt in the Fault-scar's folded sky. Something partial. Something that comes in sideways, like a note played in an adjacent room, heard through stone. The Shard stirs — the door behind your sternum shifts a fraction on its hinge — and for two or three heartbeats you are aware of a presence that is not yours and is not the room's. It is the trace of his presence. Not him. Not his will. The residue of a man who sat here for four months carrying what you now carry, writing faster as the Wellspring began to bleed beneath the mountains, feeling the same door shift in his own chest. The correspondence is real and it is old and it ends before it becomes anything you can hold. The Shard subsides. The wood is cold again. What you are left with is not knowledge — it is the specific texture of recognition, the feeling of a lock that fits a key you have been carrying without knowing it was a key, and your teacher's warning rises in the back of your throat like bile: you are not a key. You stand at the desk with your fingers still flat against the stain and your composure entirely intact because composure is what you have instead of the thing you are not going to feel right now, and behind you Passa says, very quietly: 'Your hands are shaking.'

» *Leave the room and step outside to steady myself*

You take your fingers off the desk. You do not look at Passa. You walk past her through the doorway, down the stairs, through the narrow kitchen still smelling of porridge and dark tea, and out the front door of the Undyed Cloth into Tanners' Row. The cold air of early morning hits your face and you stand in it and breathe through your nose, four counts, hold, eight counts out — the discipline your teacher taught you when you were eleven years old and did not yet know that everything he gave you was also a frame built around a door he intended to send away. The irony of using his breathing to steady yourself against the knowledge of what he did lands somewhere beneath your composure and you let it land and you do not move. The street is empty except for a carter at the far end unloading hides in the half-dark, moving with the slow economy of a man who has done this ten thousand mornings. The Fault-scar warmth rises through the cobblestones. The Shard sits behind your sternum, quiet now, the way it is always quiet after it has said something. Your hands have stopped shaking. You made them stop on the stairs. The name-token is in your pocket and the third text is in your inner coat and your teacher built a frame around a door and sent it home in a student and you are standing on a street in a foreign city with forty-four days left and you do not yet know what the Wellspring wills. You know what everyone else wills. You breathe. The city remembers it is a city: a shutter opens above you, somewhere a bell counts the hour, the carter's horse shifts its weight on the cobblestones. You are still here. That is enough, for this

exact moment. That is sufficient.

» *Walk the city and let the two facts settle beside each other*

You walk. Not toward anything. Tanners' Row gives onto a broader street of dye-merchants still shuttered, which gives onto a market square beginning its slow morning assembly — vendors unrolling canvas, a boy carrying a stack of crates taller than his head, two city guards with the particular vacancy of men ending a long night. You move through it all at the pace of someone who belongs, which is the pace you default to when you need your mind free of itself. The spear is not on your back — too conspicuous for a city this size — but the muscle-memory of its weight is still there, and you let your shoulders carry the phantom of it while you walk. The city helps, which you did not expect. It is too large and too indifferent to care about a door behind a Far-Eastern exile's sternum. A woman is arguing with a fish-seller in the rapid idiomatic Avelornian you are still mapping. A Conclave courier cuts through the square at a near-run with sealed documents under his arm and does not look at you. The Fault-scar warmth is lower here, fainter, just below perception — the city's normal floor. You walk for long enough that the sun clears the eastern spires and puts proper gold on the cobblestones, and somewhere in the third or fourth street after the market your mind stops pulling at the same two facts and starts laying them beside each other instead. Your teacher carried the Shard for eleven years and it changed him without his consent. He chose you because you already knew what

it was to refuse the shape the world assigned you. He warned you not to be a key. All of this is true. Also true: he built the frame without asking you. He made the decision that changed the entire architecture of your life — the exile, the years alone, the discipline that became composure because you had no one left to be soft with — and he made it in a room in this city while a Sealer watched, and he sent you west carrying something you did not know was there and called it your door. You stop at a low bridge over one of the city's inner canals and put your hands on the stone railing and look at the water below. He was not wrong about you. That is the part that makes the anger complicated. He read you correctly and used what he read, and those two things are not the same as love even if they were not the opposite of it either. The water moves. The Shard is quiet. You have forty-four days and a name-token in your pocket and a woman with a bisected eye who has been waiting three years for Vorn to listen. The shock is not gone. It has simply found its level, the way water does, and below the level is something that might eventually be usable. You are still here. You know what Liang Sorveth did. You do not yet know what you will do with knowing it. That is enough. That is the next honest step.

» Sit with the Shard deliberately and try to listen for what the Wellspring wills

You sit on the bridge's low parapet, facing the water, and you do the thing you have been avoiding since the Auroch Gate: you stop moving away from it and turn toward it instead.

The breathing work first. Four counts, hold, eight out. The Crane-in-Storm root planted through the stone beneath you. You let your hands rest open on your knees, palms up — not a supplicant's gesture, a receiver's — and you release the composure without abandoning it. There is a difference. Composure as armour is a closed door. Composure as discipline is a doorframe that holds the opening steady.

You press two fingers to your sternum. You do not reach for the Shard. You simply make space and wait.

It comes slowly, the way a word comes when you have been searching for it in a foreign language and suddenly the right register arrives. The warmth shifts — not the trace-resonance of the desk in room four, not the half-heard note of a mote passing through — but something present and undivided, the way a person in a room becomes present when they finally decide to speak. The door behind your sternum opens one degree further than it has ever opened before, and through the gap comes not a voice, not an image, not the folded-sky colour of voreth. Something simpler and harder to bear than any of those.

Grief. Old and vast and patient, the grief of something that agreed to be one shape for a thousand years and held that shape while the shape slowly broke, and never stopped remembering every other shape it had refused. Not human grief — grief at an entirely different scale, the way the sea is water at a different scale than a basin. But the texture of it is recognisable. You have carried

something like it since the exile.

And beneath the grief, unmistakable: will. Not the Sealers' will, not Serevaine's will, not your teacher's will. The Wellspring has not decided what it wants to become. It is still deciding. It is the colour of a thing before it decides what it is, and it has been waiting not for a key and not for a vessel but for something that already knows what it costs to refuse a shape — someone who can hear its grief without requiring it to have already made up its mind.

The door closes, gently, from the inside. Your fingers are still on your sternum. The canal water moves below you, catching the morning gold, and your composure is fully intact and something behind it is a different shape than it was a minute ago.

The Wellspring does not will the re-binding. It does not will the rupture. It wills to be heard before it is sealed or broken. It wills a witness.

You sit with that for a long time. It is not an answer. It is more important than an answer. It is the right question, finally.

Turning point: Sitting alone on the bridge with two fingers pressed to his sternum, Ming listened past the Shard and heard the Wellspring's grief directly — vast, unresolved, and unwilling to be sealed or broken before it was witnessed. The Sealers' arithmetic, Serevaine's plan, and his teacher's seventeen-year engineering all rest on an assumption the Wellspring itself has just quietly refused.

Chapter 2

The Utharvel and the Tightening Clock



» *Sit longer and try to understand whether the Shard's grief is the Wellspring's grief, or something that the Wellspring itself is still carrying.*

You do not move from the paragon. The city assembles itself around you — the canals, the vendors, the distance, the counting an hour that belongs to everyone else — and you hold very still, more alone than ever, and ask the harder question.

Not what the Wellspring wills, whether the grief you feel is the Wellspring's grief, or the Shard's grief, or whether that distinction is even real anymore after seventeen years of correspondence. You press two fingers to your sternum again, not opening the door this time — just resting against it. Listening to the structure of what is behind it the way you would listen to a joint in a weapon's haft, checking whether the grain runs true.

What you find is this: the grief has no textures. Beneath the vast oceanic grief — the grief of a will that held one shape for a thousand years — there is a smaller, older grief that is not oceanic at all. It is the grief of something removed. Something that was part of a whole and was taken from the whole and has been carried ever since in a succession of exiled bodies, passed hand to hand

across seventeen years, growing slightly more lonely with each transfer because each vessel it inhabited was already lonely and the Shard absorbed that loneliness the way wood absorbs water, slowly, completely, until the grain changes.

The Shard's grief is the Wellspring's grief, but it is also more than the Wellspring's grief. It is the accumulated grief of every exile who carried it. Your teacher's eleven years. Your seventeen. The Shard is not a fragment that has been waiting, neutral and inert, to be returned. It has been changed by what it passed through. Which means — and here the thought lands in your chest like a spear-tip finding purchase — the Wellspring, if it receives the Shard back, receives everything the Shard absorbed. Every exile. Every year of Liang Sorveth writing faster as the sky bled above the Auric Mountains. Every morning you spent alone with a breathing practice and a composure that stood in for the softness you had no one left to give.

The Wellspring asked for a witness. It may not have understood that the witness was already inside what it lost.

» Sit longer still and try to ask the Shard directly whether it wants to return — whether it has a will of its own after seventeen years

You stay with the question longer than is comfortable. The city moves around you. A woman crosses the bridge behind you without slowing, her footsteps receding into Tanners' Row. The canal water catches the mid-morning

light and breaks it into pieces. You press two fingers to your sternum and you ask the Shard directly, as plainly as you asked Serevaine her arithmetic: do you want to return. After seventeen years do you have a will of your own. And if you do, what is it.

The door does not open.

Not resistance — not a refusal in the way a locked room refuses. More like silence where you expected an answer, the way a student goes quiet not from stubbornness but because the question has arrived before they have the language to answer it. The warmth is present. The Shard is present. But whatever you reached for when you asked — the discrete will, the clean yes or no, the thing that would let you treat this as an honest negotiation between two parties — it does not cohere. The correspondence your teacher wrote about is real, you can feel its texture, but correspondence is not the same as separability. You cannot find where the Shard ends and where seventeen years of Ming begins. You cannot find the seam.

You sit with the failure of the question for a long time. Your fingers are still at your sternum. What you are left with is not an answer but a sharper problem: you cannot ask the Shard what it wills because you cannot yet determine whether the Shard is still a thing that is separate enough from you to will anything independently. The third text said the door and the frame cannot be taken apart without consequence to both. You understood that as a warning about the ritual. You

understand it now as something more immediate. You are not carrying a fragment. You are carrying something that may have become, in some way you have no language for, partly yourself. And you do not know if that makes the offering more possible or less.

» Find the Thornwood shamans in the city — they have lore of voreth and the Wellspring that predates the Covenant, and they may have a different language for what you experienced

You open your eyes. The canal water is still moving. You are still here, on the parapet, with a problem that has no clean edges — and a thread you have not yet pulled. Serevaine has Grey-Faction knowledge. The Sealers have Covenant-text. But the Thornwood were in this land before anyone bound anything. They named voreth. They named the Wellspring's grief before the First Archmages decided to solve it. If any lore predates the framing that everyone else is still trapped inside, it belongs to them.

You rise from the parapet, roll your shoulders once to settle the phantom weight of the absent spear, and begin asking.

It takes the better part of the morning. The Thornwood do not announce themselves in Veranthos — they are here because refugees come to gate-cities when the ground shakes, not because they were welcomed. The first person you ask, a hide-seller in the market, looks at you with the flattened expression of a man who has been a foreigner in this city long enough to recognize

another one, and says nothing. The second is more useful — a canal-worker with the Thornwood clan-braid half-hidden under a dock-worker's cap who looks at your face for a long moment, then tells you: the Unsutured keep to the south end of Coppervane, in a courtyard behind the rendered-fat chandler, and they do not see people who are not brought.

The third person, a girl of perhaps twelve carrying a basket of tallow-dips through the Stitchway, simply turns and walks ahead of you without being asked, which means she was watching you ask, and you follow her through three back-passages that smell of fat and old smoke into a courtyard that the city's main arteries do not acknowledge.

The courtyard holds a fire — small, efficient, burning something that smells like pine-resin and stone-dust. Around it, four people in the heavy-woven cloaks of the Thornwood hill-country. They look at you the way people look at something they have been warned about in a language that does not have a word for warning. An old man with a face like a map of a hard country sits nearest the fire. The girl with the basket sets it down and fades to the edge of the courtyard without a word. The old man says, in trade-tongue that is accented but entirely precise: 'You smell of the deep fault. And of something older than the fault.' He studies your sternum with the directness of a man who does not need to pretend he is looking at your face. 'Sit down. You have been carrying that for a very long time, and you have questions, and

some of them are the right questions. I can tell by the way you are standing that you already know the grief.' He gestures at the ground across the fire from him. 'My name is Orrath. We are called Unsutured because we do not stitch the Wellspring's mouth shut and call that a solution. Sit.'

» Say nothing yet — sit, let the fire settle, and let him lead; he said some of your questions are the right ones, and you want to know which

You sit. Cross-legged, hands open on your knees, the same posture you held on the bridge parapet — receiver's posture, not supplicant's. The fire between you and Orrath is small and speaks in the language of fires that are fed with intention: slow, even, unhurried. The pine-resin smell settles into your clothes. The courtyard is quiet in the specific way of places that have been made quiet deliberately, where the noise of Coppervane exists on the other side of a wall that is not only stone.

Orrath does not rush you. He does not fill the silence with the small talk of a man performing patience. He simply tends the fire with a stick the length of a forearm, making tiny adjustments, and watches the space above your sternum with the directness he has already established. The three others in the courtyard are present but peripheral — they do not watch you the way he watches you. They watch him watching you, which is different.

After a time that has no particular length, Orrath sets the stick across his knees and speaks. His trade-tongue is

accented in the way of a man who learned it as a fourth or fifth language, each word chosen with deliberate weight. 'You asked it something this morning,' he says. It is not a question. 'Something you could not get an answer to. Not because it refused. Because the question assumed a separation that is no longer there.' He tilts his head a fraction. 'We have a word for that condition. Not voreth — voreth is what comes before the choosing. This is what comes after the choosing when the boundary of the choosing has dissolved.' He pauses. 'In your language I do not know the word. In ours it is utharvel. A thing that has been two things long enough that it is now a third thing, and the third thing does not yet have a name because no one has looked at it clearly enough to name it.' His eyes come up from your sternum to your face. 'The right questions you already carry are these: not whether the Shard wants to return, and not whether you will survive the offering. Those are the wrong frame.' He holds up one finger. 'The right question is what the third thing — the utharvel, the Ming-Shard — is, and whether the Wellspring has ever received that before. Something that loved it and changed while carrying it.' A second finger. 'And the right question beneath that one is whether the Wellspring, which has also been changing in its binding for a thousand years, is also utharvel now. Also a third thing. Also something that does not yet have a name.' He lowers both fingers and looks at you with the expression of a man who has been waiting a long time to say something to someone who might actually hear it. 'The Covenant texts ask: how

do we seal it. The Quietists ask: how do we free it. Both questions assume the Wellspring is still what it was when it was bound.' He pauses once more, and this pause has the weight of something he has been holding for years. 'We do not think it is.'

» Ask Orrath what the Thornwood believe the Wellspring has become — what the utharvel of a bound god looks like after a thousand years

Orrath is quiet for long enough that the fire speaks between you — a small shift of resin, a breath of pine-smoke moving east. The three others at the courtyard's edge have gone very still. Whatever you just asked, it landed in a different register than the questions that preceded it. You watch Orrath's face make a decision that is not about trust exactly — more like the decision a teacher makes when a student asks the question that means they are finally ready to be told the thing the teacher has been waiting to say for years, and the telling will change the shape of the lesson permanently.

'We do not use the word god,' Orrath says, carefully. 'That word belongs to a frame we do not use. But we have watched the Wellspring for longer than the Covenant has existed, and we have watched it change.' He lifts the stick from his knees and touches it to the fire's edge — not stoking, just contact. 'When it was first bound, a thousand years ago, we felt the binding happen. Our oldest texts say it screamed without sound for seven years. A god-grief. The grief of a will forced into a single form, the way you might force a river into a pipe.' He pauses. 'We expected it to stop grieving. It did

not. It grieved for a hundred years, two hundred, and then something happened that we do not have a full account of, only the felt sense of it passed down through every shaman in our line.' He looks up from the fire to your sternum. 'It began to dream.'

Behind your sternum the Shard is entirely still, the stillness of something listening with every part of itself.

'A bound will, given long enough in the binding, does not simply endure. It turns inward. It makes an interior. The Wellspring has spent a thousand years dreaming itself into shapes it was never allowed to be — all the refused forms, all the voreth-colours, all the things it might have become if the First Archmages had not needed it to be one manageable thing.' Orrath sets the stick down across his knees again, with the finality of a man reaching the part of the telling that costs something. 'What we believe the Wellspring has become is this: it is no longer the thing the Archmages bound. It is also no longer the wild unformed thing they bound it from. It has spent a thousand years in the dark becoming something neither of those things. Something that has grief in it, and dreaming in it, and a thousand years of interior life that no one has ever asked about.' His eyes come all the way up to yours. 'You felt the grief this morning. Did you feel what was underneath the grief?'

He waits. It is the first time since you sat down that he has asked you a question rather than naming what he already knows. He is asking because he genuinely does not know the answer — because the Shard was inside

you when you listened, and he was not, and whatever is underneath the grief of a thousand-year dreaming god is something the Unsutured have felt only in outline, from the outside, through the Fault-scars and the folded sky, while you were sitting on a bridge with two fingers on your sternum touching it directly.

» Say nothing yet. Press two fingers to your sternum and open to the Shard here, in the courtyard, with Orrath watching — let him see what you see.

You press two fingers to your sternum and open the door.

What comes is not what came on the bridge. The bridge was private, the question was patient, the city was indifferent. This is a fire and a watching man and pine-resin smoke and the weight of the Unsutured's attention on your chest — and the Shard, which has been patient all morning, does not open cleanly. The door shifts and something comes through the gap but it comes wrong, the way a word comes wrong in a foreign language when you are tired and the register slips: you feel the grief, the old oceanic grief, and beneath it you reach for what Orrath is asking about, the thing underneath, the interior life, the thousand years of dreaming — and you cannot hold it. It arrives in fragments. Something vast and turned inward. Something that has been making, in the dark, shapes it will never be allowed to show anyone. Something like joy, maybe — but a joy so long unwitnessed it has become indistinguishable from longing, and you cannot tell them apart, and you lose the thread. The warmth behind your sternum flares once, irregular, and subsides. The door closes.

You open your eyes. You do not know when you closed them. Orrath is watching your face with the precise attention of a man who has learned to read the outside of a thing he cannot touch directly, and you know from his expression that what he saw was not a clean transmission. He saw the reach. He saw the failure of the reach. He saw you lose the thread at the exact moment it mattered.

You lower your hand from your sternum. The courtyard is still. The fire is still. You say, in trade-tongue, with the economy of a man reporting an honest result: 'Something like joy. I could not hold it long enough to be certain. It would not come clearly with witnesses.' You pause, and then add the harder part: 'Or I am not yet the right kind of witness.'

» We sit and have food in silent. Then I ask if they want to go to the Willspring with me.

Passa's food arrives without explanation — the girl with the tallow-basket reappears from somewhere with a cloth bundle that turns out to contain flatbread, hard cheese, and two small clay cups of something warm and bitter that the Thornwood drink the way you drink dark morning tea. You eat in silence. The fire speaks. Orrath eats with the same economical attention he gives everything else, and the three others eat without looking at you, which is its own form of acceptance. The food is plain and adequate and you finish all of it, because the body that carries the Shard is still a body. When the cups are empty and the cloth bundle is folded and the

fire has settled into its quieter afternoon register, you set your hands on your knees and look at Orrath across the coals and say, in trade-tongue, with the plainness of a man stating a route: 'I am going to the Wellspring. Not to the fifth-point of the ritual geometry. Not yet. To listen — to be the kind of witness it asked for, from closer than a bridge in Coppervane.' A pause. 'I am asking if you want to come.' The courtyard holds the question. Orrath does not answer immediately. He looks at your sternum, then at your face, then at the fire, with the unhurried attention of a man checking three different instruments before he reads the weather. One of the three others at the edge of the courtyard — a younger woman with the hill-country braid and a stillness that suggests she has been listening to every word since you arrived — looks up from the coals and looks at Orrath with an expression that is not quite a question and not quite a plea. Orrath sets his cup down. He says, slowly: 'The Unsutured have not walked to the Auric Mountains in eleven years. The last time, the Sealers turned us back at the foothills.' Another pause. 'But you are carrying the inside of it. And I have been watching the outside for sixty years and I have never spoken to anyone who touched what you touched this morning.' He is quiet for a long moment. 'This is not a small thing you are asking.'

» I am going there in three days. You know how to find me in this city. Then I left and start to dig out the mages intention and the story from their side.

You stand, which closes the question without closing the door. 'Three days,' you say. 'You know where to find me.'

Orrath looks at you from across the dying fire with the expression of a man who has been given a thing he was not certain he would ever receive, and is now uncertain what it weighs. He does not say yes. He does not say no. He says: 'Three days.' And the way he says it — the weight he gives the number — tells you it is neither acceptance nor refusal but something more honest than either: a shaman checking whether the ground will hold before he steps onto it. You leave the courtyard the way you entered it, through the back-passages, and the girl with the tallow-basket is not there to guide you out, which means you find it yourself, which means you were watching on the way in. You were.

The Conclave district is north of Coppervane, past Lamplighter's Arch — the part of Veranthos where the ley-lanterns run brightest and the blue threadwork is not embroidered on cuffs but hung above doorways like flags. You go there with the economy of a man who has decided on a route, and you find what you expected to find: the Arcane College is a working institution under siege conditions, which means it is both fortified and porous. Sealed doors and nervous functionaries and couriers moving in and out with the compressed urgency of people who know the Clock is running. A partial success at reading the shape of it — enough to see the outline, not enough to see the interior. What you read clearly: the Sealers are afraid, and their fear has curdled into motion. They are not deliberating any longer. They are executing. You overhear a fragment of argument near the eastern gate between two robed figures — one

senior, one junior — about the fourth shrine-component, whether it has been secured, whether the timeline allows for the journey. The senior figure says: 'The Archmagister has already decided. The ritual window opens in thirty-one days.' What you do not read clearly: who else the Conclave has spoken to, what they know about the fifth component, whether Vorn has any doubt at all about her incomplete text. The junior robed figure glances at you once — a foreigner loitering near a gate — and you move on before the glance becomes a question.

» I decided to get my weapon first as my journey will begin in three days.

You turn away from the Conclave district and walk back through Lamplighter's Arch toward the Undyed Cloth with the particular purpose of a man who has finished one kind of work and started another. The spear is in your room, wrapped in oiled cloth and leaned against the wall behind the door — you left it there this morning because a foreigner carrying a six-foot weapon draws a different kind of attention than a foreigner asking questions. You take the stairs two at a time, which is not composure exactly but is its cousin.

The room is as you left it. The spear is where you left it. You unwrap the oiled cloth and take the haft in both hands and stand with it for a moment in the narrow space between bed and window, not in form, just holding it — the weight redistributing itself through your palms the way it always does, the grain of the ash familiar

enough that your hands know it in the dark. The Crane-in-Storm spear form was built around a body that was already carrying something it did not know it was carrying, which means the form was shaped, at least in part, by the Shard's presence in Liang Sorveth before you, and you do not know yet what that means for the form you learned from him. You set the thought aside. The weapon is sound. The tip needs no work. The binding at the lower third is slightly dry and you take ten minutes with the oil and a strip of cloth to address it properly, because three days is enough time to do this correctly and a spear that fails at altitude in the cold is a different problem than a spear that needs attention now.

When it is done you stand the spear against the wall and look at it. It is the one thing you brought across the sea that belongs entirely to you — not a text someone wrote to instruct your choices, not a token pressed into your hands by a woman keeping faith with a dead man's instructions, not a fragment of something ancient lodged behind your sternum without your consent. Yours. The composure settles back into place around that fact and stays there.

Three days. The Conclave's ritual window opens in thirty-one. Vorn has committed to an incomplete text and does not know it. Serevaine wants the Shard delivered. Orrath has not said no. The Wellspring wants a witness. And you have a weapon, a third text, a name-token, and seventeen years of a Crane-in-Storm form built around a door. You have been in worse positions, though you are

having difficulty at this exact moment remembering when.

» *Practice in the yard, get myself ready.*

The Undyed Cloth has a yard — barely. A strip of packed earth behind the kitchen, bounded by a stone wall on two sides and the back of a dyer's shed on the third, smelling of old mordant and clean dirt. Passa is somewhere inside. The yard is empty. It is enough.

You shed your outer coat, take the spear in both hands, and begin.

Not combat forms. Not the high-intensity sequences that end with the tip at a throat. The root work first — the Crane-in-Storm foundation that your teacher built the entire form around, which means the foundation your teacher built around a door he was already planning to pass to you, which you know now and which you hold at a distance while your feet find their positions in the packed earth. The body does not need to settle the question of Liang Sorveth to do this work. The body knows the form. The body has known it for seventeen years and the fact that it was built around a secret does not unmake what you made of it in the years after. You have thought of this before, with other things. A technique taught by a flawed teacher is still a technique. You keep what works.

You run the first sequence slow — thinking-speed, each position held three full breaths, feeling where the weight sits, where the Shard sits, whether they are in correspondence or in conflict today. They are not in

conflict. The warmth behind your sternum tracks the spear-tip the way it sometimes does in long forms, a faint attentiveness, and you let it track without comment. The door stays closed. The Shard does not need to speak into this. It watches, and you work, and the yard is very quiet except for the sound of ash-wood moving through morning air and your breathing, which is four counts, hold, eight counts out, the rhythm so old it requires nothing of you now except that you do not stop.

The second sequence comes faster. The third faster still. By the fourth you are no longer thinking about Orrath or the Conclave's thirty-one-day window or what utharvel means for the geometry of the offering — you are in the form and the form is in you and the spear is a six-foot extension of a question your body has been asking since you were nineteen years old and exiled and standing on a dock with everything taken and the form still in your hands, still intact, still yours. You practice until your shoulders ache with the good ache of honest work, until the sweat on your back cools in the early afternoon air, until the yard is longer than it was when you started because you have stopped seeing the walls.

You bring the spear back to guard and hold it there. Your breathing is even. Your composure is not the same thing as calm — it never has been — but right now it is close enough that the distinction does not matter. You are ready. Not for the offering, not for the Wellspring's grief or Vorn's incomplete text or Serevaine's arithmetic. Ready for the next three days. That is the right unit of

readiness.

» *Seek out what the Coppervane merchant district knows about the road to the Auric Mountains and what lies between here and the foothills*

You wrap the spear in its oiled cloth and lean it against the wall, pull your outer coat back on, and walk north through Tanners' Row into Coppervane with the particular economy of a man conducting reconnaissance. The merchant district in the early afternoon is at its most useful — the morning rush has settled, the serious traders are in back rooms doing serious arithmetic, and the people left visible on the street are the ones who have time to talk, which usually means they have something to say.

You start with cartographers. There is one on the Coppervane main thoroughfare — a narrow shop wedged between a spice importer and a moneychanger, run by a compact woman with ink-stained fingers who looks at you the way cartographers look at everyone: as a potential customer with a specific problem. You buy a route-map of the western roads for two silver marks, which is twice the going rate and which she accepts without comment, and while she rolls it you ask, in trade-tongue, about the road to the Auric Mountains. She tells you what the map already shows — the King's Road west out of the Auroch Gate, three days to the foothills at a good pace, four if the road is soft from Fault-heat, which it has been. She adds, without prompting, that the waystation at Helvrath's Cross is not operating — closed six weeks ago when the warden abandoned it. 'People

have been abandoning the road west,' she says, without particular drama. 'Not stupidity. Pragmatism.' She hands you the rolled map.

The second useful conversation happens at a teamster's yard near the Coppervane canal landing, where a broad man named Dusset who runs supply-wagons to the mining concerns in the foothills is willing to talk because you bought him a cup of something warm from the stall across the lane. He has stopped running wagons west for three weeks. The reasons, in order: the road past Helvrath's Cross has Fault-scars that are no longer small and warm but wide and bright and loud, audible at night as a low harmonic that gets into the teeth and makes the horses refuse; there are Conclave checkpoints at two points on the King's Road — established four days ago, with blue-threadwork wardens who turn back commercial traffic and ask questions about cargo; and there is something wrong with the Greyveil bridge, the only reliable crossing of the Sullen River before the foothills, though he cannot say what exactly except that the last driver who came back from it would not describe what he saw and drank for two days after.

You leave Dusset with the map tucked inside your coat and a cleaner picture of what three days of preparation actually needs to address. The road is passable but watched. The Fault is louder and wider than it was. There is something at the Greyveil bridge that a teamster who crosses rivers for a living refused to

describe. Checkpoints four days ago means the Sealers have begun securing the approach faster than their thirty-one-day window suggests. You have a spear, an incomplete text, a name-token, and seventeen years of a form built around a door. The next question is whether you solve the checkpoints before you leave, or solve them when you reach them.

» *Find legitimate cover for the journey — a trader, a pilgrim group, anything that gets you through a Conclave checkpoint without questions about cargo*

You spend the remainder of the afternoon working the problem. A legitimate cover — a trader's manifest, a pilgrim group, a carter's invoice — is the clean solution, the one that costs nothing at the checkpoint and leaves no memory in a warden's mind. You are methodical about it. You ask at three trading houses about westward caravans; two have suspended western runs entirely, and the third looks at you with the flat eyes of a man who knows a foreigner asking about western cargo is not asking about western cargo. You find a Quietist pilgrim circle that walks to the mountain shrines on a seasonal circuit — but their departure is ten days out and their leader, a small careful woman who asks too many questions about why you are in Veranthos, does not give you the feeling of someone who will be incurious at a checkpoint. You find a herbalist's supply run that goes as far as Helvrath's Cross — but it stopped running when the waystation closed and the driver is not resuming until the road is confirmed passable, which is to say never. By the time the afternoon light has gone

copper and the ley-lanterns are warming in their housings along the Coppervane thoroughfare, you have found nothing that holds. Every cover requires either a wait you cannot afford or a dependency on someone who will notice the spear, notice the way you carry yourself, notice the thing behind your sternum that makes the Fault-scar warmth flicker when you stand too long in one place. The city is contracting. The people who move westward freely are the Conclave's own people, and they do not need cover because they are the checkpoint. You stand outside the cartographer's shop with the rolled map inside your coat and the honest result of the afternoon in your hands: you found nothing. The checkpoints will have to be solved when you reach them, not before.

» I will punch my way out, checkpoint won't be a problem. Get some Intel and the missing piece from Conclave and mages before departure.

You stand outside the cartographer's shop and let the afternoon settle around the failed search. The cover problem has a clean solution: there is no cover to find. The checkpoints are Conclave wardens. Conclave wardens carry orders, not wisdom. A foreigner with a spear and a straight back who does not flinch at their questions is less suspicious than a foreigner with a forged manifest who flinches at their questions. You will walk through them on your own terms or go around them, and you will decide which when you see what is in front of you. The problem is filed and closed.

The missing piece is the harder problem. Not the

checkpoints — the Conclave's knowledge. You know they are executing against an incomplete text. You know they have thirty-one days and four shrine-components and no fifth. What you do not know is what else they know: whether Vorn has any surviving doubt, whether there are Sealer scholars who have found the same gap in the Covenant-text that Serevaine found, whether anyone inside the blue threadwork has handled the arithmetic of the fifth component and quietly set it aside because it was inconvenient. This is the intelligence worth carrying west.

You spend the last of the afternoon working the district's edges — not the Conclave district itself, which is locked down and watching, but its penumbra: the ink-merchants who supply the college, the boarding houses where junior scholars stay when the college's own rooms are full, the tavern near Lamplighter's Arch where the Conclave's working staff drink after the late shift. You are economical and patient. You buy two cups of wine you do not drink and listen to conversations you were not invited into. What you gather: the Archmagister has sealed internal debate — two senior scholars who raised questions about the Covenant-text's completeness were reassigned to component-transport duty six days ago, which is the Conclave's version of silencing. One of them, a narrow-faced man called Edric Vaun who now apparently drinks alone at the Lamplighter's Arch tavern after his reassignment, says nothing useful when you sit near him — but he looks at the Fault-scar warmth bleeding through the tavern floor with the expression of

a man who has done arithmetic that arrived at a wrong answer and knows it and has been told not to say so. He looks at the warmth for a long time. He does not look at you. But when you stand to leave he says, quietly, in Avelornian you mostly follow: 'If someone were going west, they would want to know the fourth component reached the staging camp two days ago. Thirty-one days was already tight. It is tighter now.' He does not look up from his cup.

You walk back to the Undyed Cloth with this: the Conclave's timeline has compressed. The fourth component is already at the staging camp in the foothills — which means Vorn will not wait the full thirty-one days. She will move when the geometry allows it. You do not know when that is. You know it is sooner than you planned for, and three days is now a number that has to hold against an unknown pressure. You are going west in three days. You will solve the checkpoints when you reach them. You have a spear, a map, a third text, a Thornwood shaman who has not said no, and seventeen years of a form built around a door that is also, it turns out, partly you. It is enough. It has to be enough.

Turning point: The reassigned Conclave scholar Edric Vaun, staring at the Fault-warmth bleeding through the tavern floor without once meeting Ming's eyes, quietly spoke the words that compressed everything: the fourth ritual component had reached the foothills staging camp two days early.

Archmagister Vorn was not waiting thirty-one days — she would move when the geometry allowed it, and the geometry was already assembling itself without him. Three days had just become a number under unknown pressure.

Chapter 3

The Answer, Not the Key



» Find Edric Vaun again tomorrow and press harder — a man reassigned for asking the right question may be willing to say more with less wine in front of him.

Morning. You are at the Unfolded Cloth before the city has fully decided to begin, eating Pasha's bread with the map unrolled across the table and the third text folded inside your coat. You know where Edric Vaun will be — a reassigned scholar given component-transport duty still has to report somewhere, and transport officers who drink alone at Lamplighter's Arms after shift do not vary their mornings much. You find him at a tea-house two streets from the Corner, near the eastern gate, sitting with a cup and a ledger. He is not smiling, wearing the expression of a man who went to sleep with the same wrong answer he woke up with.

You sit across from him without asking. He looks up. Looks at your sternum — not the way Garath looked at it, not with a shaman's reading, but with the judiciousary focus of a man who has done enough Fault-resonance work to feel warmth when it is close. His composure adjusts. He does not leave.

You set nothing on the table. No wine, no coin, no paper. You say, in trade-tongue, with the economy of a teacher explaining a technique to a student who has not yet

earned the full explanation: 'You were reassigned for asking about the text's completeness. Tell me what you found.' A pause, exactly as long as needed. 'I am not Conclave. I am not Quietist. I am a man who needs to know whether Vorn understands what she is walking into.' Vaun looks at his ledger, then at the tea-house door, then at you. The calculation he runs takes perhaps four seconds. Then he says, in low Avelornian you follow well enough: 'The cardinal geometry has five convergence points. Every foundational text agrees. But the Archmagister's working draft acknowledges only four shrine-components and treats the fifth point as a passive anchor — a fixed locus in the mountain's own stone.' He stops. You wait. He continues: 'I argued the passive-anchor reading was a transcription error, not a deliberate choice. That the original Covenant required an active fifth element. Something living.' His voice drops further. 'She said the mountain would provide. Those were her exact words. The mountain would provide.' He finally looks at you directly, and what is in his face is not fear exactly but the specific exhaustion of a man who has been right about something terrible for weeks and has not been allowed to say so. 'If she is wrong — if the fifth point fires without an active element — the geometry inverts. The re-binding becomes a rupture-accelerator. Not in thirty-one days. Immediately.' He closes the ledger. 'I do not know why I am telling a foreign spearman this.' You say: 'Because I asked without wine in front of you.' Something shifts in his expression — not quite trust, but the first degree of it. He says: 'The

staging camp is at Thornheel, three miles into the foothills past the Greyveil bridge. Vorn moves when all four components are assembled and the geometric window opens. Her astronomers put that window at twenty-two days, not thirty-one. The twenty-two-day figure is not public.' He stands, tucks the unread ledger under his arm, and looks at you once more. 'Whatever the mountain provides,' he says, 'I hope it knows what it is doing.' He walks out. You sit with your tea and the weight of twenty-two days instead of thirty-one, and the image of a geometry inverting, and the word rupture-accelerant, which is a cleaner and more terrible version of what Serevaine's arithmetic already told you.

» Spend the day in preparation: study the third text again for anything about the geometric inversion risk, then rest and be ready to depart at first light

You walk back to the Undyed Cloth through the warming morning, Vaun's last words settling into the same register as the third text's warning — different voices, same arithmetic. You climb the stairs, set the spear against the wall, unroll the route-map across the foot of the bed, and unfold the third text across your knees.

You read it slowly and in order, which is not how you have read it before. Before, you searched it for answers to specific questions. Now you read it the way you read terrain before a journey — looking not for what you need but for what is there. Your Avelornian is poor, but the third text is in your teacher's hand, in Zhennian, and your Zhennian is native. Liang Sorveth wrote in the compressed style of a man who knew he was writing for

one reader and did not need to explain the frame. What you find, on the fourth page, in the margin, in smaller characters than the body text — characters so small and so close-pressed that you have looked at this page perhaps thirty times and read them as ornamentation: a technical note. Not about the offering. About the geometry. Your teacher knew the five-point structure. He described it from a different source than the Covenant-text — an older account, possibly Thornwood in origin. The fifth point is not passive and was never passive. The original word in the old account is not 'anchor.' It is 'answer.' The fifth convergence point requires the geometry to be answered — a living will completing a circuit that the four shrine-components can only open. Without the answer, the circuit opens and does not close, and the Fault underneath the mountain reads an open circuit as rupture. The word Sorveth uses for what happens then is not rupture-accelerant. It is older and simpler. He calls it an unasking — the question the Archmages asked of the Wellspring a thousand years ago, asked again, with no one present who can respond.

You sit with this for a long time. The difference between a key and an answer is not small. A key is used. An answer is given. Your teacher underlined his own margin-note once, lightly, with the flat of his nail rather than ink — a habit he had when he wanted to mark something without marking it permanently. You fold the third text with the care it has always received, tuck it inside your coat, and lie down on the bed with your hands open at your sides and the spear against the wall and the route-

map at your feet, and you rest. The Shard is warm and quiet behind your sternum. Outside, Veranthos counts its hours. Twenty-two days. First light. You close your eyes and let the body do what the body knows how to do when it has been given honest work and an honest reckoning: it rests, and readies, and waits for morning.

» Depart immediately at first light — Orrath knows the meeting point, and twenty-two days does not allow for waiting

First light arrives the way it does in a city that has stopped trusting mornings — thin, cautious, the ley-lanterns still warm in their housings when you descend the stairs with your coat on and the spear across your back and the third text inside your coat and the name-token in your breast pocket where it has been since Passa gave it to you. Passa is already in the kitchen. She looks at the spear, then at your face, then at the spear again, and does not ask. She puts bread and a boiled egg in your hands and says, in trade-tongue: 'You will come back.' It is not a question. You do not lie to her. You say: 'The room is paid through the month.' She holds your gaze for a moment with the expression of a woman who has been keeping faith with absent people for seventeen years and knows exactly what that answer costs, and then she turns back to her work. You eat the bread and the egg standing in the doorway and leave before the street has filled.

The Auroch Gate is quieter at first light than at midday — fewer traders, more wardens, the sky above the arch still showing the faintest edge of voreth in the west

where the dark has not yet decided to become morning. You walk through without slowing. The wardens look at the spear. You look at the road. Neither party asks the other a question.

Orrath is waiting at the first milestone west of the gate. He is alone, which is not what you expected — but when you look past him you see the younger woman with the hill-country braid standing twenty feet back, pack on her back, not pretending she is not there. Orrath says: 'She is called Davan. She is the better shaman. I am the one who speaks trade-tongue.' He studies your face in the early light with the unhurried attention you already know from the courtyard. 'You look like a man who found something in a text last night.' You say: 'The fifth point does not need an anchor. It needs an answer.' Orrath is quiet for three full seconds. Then he says, in a voice that carries no surprise and considerable weight: 'Yes. We have been saying that for eleven years.' He turns west. Davan falls in behind him without a word. You fall in beside them, the spear across your back, the Shard warm and attentive behind your sternum, the King's Road stretching west toward the foothills and the Greyveil bridge and whatever is wrong there, and the Auric Mountains beyond that holding twenty-two days and a geometry that needs not a key but an answer.

The road is good for the first hour. Then the Fault-scars begin.

» Ask Davan directly what she knows about the Greyveil bridge — Orrath said she is the better shaman

The Fault-scars begin as hairline warmth bleeding up through the road's stone, faint enough that you might dismiss them as morning sun on pale rock. Then wider. Then the first one that crosses the full width of the King's Road — a finger's breadth of luminous amber threading between the paving stones like a seam in old pottery, warm enough that you feel it through your boot-soles when you step across. The road west of Veranthos is not the road that was here a month ago. You walk in single file by instinct, Orrath in the middle, Davan behind. After the third wide scar, you slow your pace and turn to look at her directly.

'Orrath said you are the better shaman.' You do not soften it with preamble. 'The Greyveil bridge. The teamster who crossed it would not describe what he saw and drank for two days after. What do you know about it?' It is the most words you have directed at her since the milestone. You wait.

Davan is quiet for long enough that you begin to wonder if the trade-tongue question was understood. Then she speaks — trade-tongue, accented differently from Orrath's, rougher at the consonants, but precise in the same way, the way of people who learned a language by needing it rather than studying it. Her voice is low and unhurried. 'The bridge is old. Older than the King's Road. The Covenant was already failing when the road-builders sank the footings.' She watches the nearest Fault-scar as she speaks, not you. 'What the bridge sits on is not stone anymore. Fault-heat has been running

under the river at that crossing for six months. The stone is still stone in shape. But it is listening.' A pause. 'What the teamster saw was probably the bridge responding to weight. It does not do what bridges do — it does what the Fault wants it to do, and the Fault is asking a question that stone was not built to ask.' She looks up at you then, with the directness she has been withholding until now. 'If you walk onto it expecting a bridge, you will have a problem. If you walk onto it expecting a threshold — something that checks what is crossing — you will have a different problem, but one that can be answered.' Her eyes move to your sternum for the first time, the same involuntary focus Vaun showed, but slower and more deliberate. 'What you carry will be noticed. The bridge will know what you are before you reach the middle.' Orrath, ahead of you, does not turn around, but says in his precise trade-tongue: 'She has crossed Fault-thresholds before. In the eastern ranges. I have not.' He says this as a simple statement of relevant fact, the way a good teacher acknowledges a student's superior skill in a specific discipline. Davan does not acknowledge the compliment. She is still watching your sternum.

» Ask Davan what answering a Fault-threshold looks like in practice — what she did in the eastern ranges

The road has widened its scars. The last one you crossed left a faint harmonic in your boot-soles that took three steps to fade — not painful, more like a word spoken below the threshold of hearing that the body registers before the mind does. Davan walks beside you now rather than behind, which is not a small shift. She

did not announce it. She simply moved.

You ask her: 'What does answering a Fault-threshold look like in practice? What did you do in the eastern ranges?'

She is quiet for perhaps twenty paces. Not the quiet of a woman deciding whether to answer, but the quiet of a woman finding the right frame for something that resists framing. Then: 'The eastern thresholds are smaller. Older. The Fault there has been asking its question for a long time and has grown accustomed to silence — so the question has worn smooth, like a stone in a river. You can feel the shape of it before you step onto the threshold.' She pauses, watching the road. 'What I did was this: I stopped at the threshold's edge and I let it feel me before I felt it. Not passive — I was present, fully present, the way you are present in a form that requires your whole attention. But I did not push a question back at it. I waited until it had finished reading me, and then I answered what it actually asked, not what I expected it to ask.' She looks at you sidelong. 'The mistake people make is answering the question they prepared for. Thresholds do not ask the question you are afraid of. They ask the question that is true.' Another pause, shorter. 'In the eastern ranges, the threshold asked me whether I had come to take or to witness. That is all. I said: to witness. I believed it when I said it, and the threshold knew I believed it, and it let me through.' She is quiet again, then adds, in a lower register: 'What the Greyveil threshold will ask you — I do not know. What

you carry changes the question. The Shard is a refused shape, a thing that said no to becoming the Wellspring and has been carried in exile for a thousand years inside bodies that also said no to the shape assigned to them.' She does not look at your sternum this time. She looks at the road ahead, where the river-crossing is still invisible but the air above it already has a quality that is not quite heat and not quite light. 'It may ask you something no one has been asked before. Because what you are is something that has not crossed a Fault-threshold before.' Orrath, walking ahead, says without turning: 'This is why I said she is the better shaman.' Davan does not acknowledge this either.

» Tell Davan and Orrath what Sorveth's margin-note says about the fifth point — they have held the answer-reading for eleven years and deserve to know the full text before you reach the bridge

You walk for a few paces after she finishes, and then you stop. Not because the road requires it — the road is good here, the Fault-scars still narrow and crossable — but because what you are about to say wants a stopped body, a deliberate moment. Orrath and Davan stop when you stop, without question, the way people who have learned to read terrain stop when the person who has been reading it stops.

You take the third text from inside your coat. You do not unfold it — the Avelornian road is not the place to lay out the full account — but you hold it in both hands and you say, in trade-tongue, with the economy of a man reporting an honest result: 'My teacher hid a note in the

margin of this text. I found it two nights ago. I have read it twice now and I am certain of it.' You look at Orrath first, then Davan. 'The fifth convergence point — the one the Sealers are treating as a passive anchor. He had a different source. Older, possibly Thornwood in origin. He said the original word for the fifth point is not anchor. It is answer. A living will completing the circuit the four shrine-components open.' A pause. 'Without the answer, the geometry reads as an open circuit. He calls the result an unasking — the question the Archmages asked of the Wellspring a thousand years ago, asked again with no one present who can respond.' You say the Zhennian word quietly and then its trade-tongue rendering, so there is no room for translation error. 'He also wrote: a key is used. An answer is given. He underlined it — not with ink. With his thumbnail. He did not want to mark the page permanently.' You hold the folded text for another moment, then put it back inside your coat. 'You have been saying this for eleven years from outside. He said it from inside, in a margin, in a script no one here reads, for an audience of one. I think you should know that your eleven years and his hidden note arrive at the same word.'

Orrath is very still. The quality of his stillness has changed — it is no longer the patience of a man waiting for something he expects, but the stillness of a man receiving something that confirms a weight he has been carrying alone. He says, after a long moment, in a voice that has dropped a register: 'Your teacher's source. The phrasing — refused shapes, a will forced into a single

form.' He does not make it a question, but he is asking. Davan has not moved. She is watching the folded text inside your coat the way she watched the Fault-scar warmth on the tavern floor — the involuntary attention of someone who feels where the weight is. Then she says, quietly: 'The Thornwood source Sorveth used — if it is the account I know — it also says what the answer costs the one who gives it. It does not say the cost is death. It says the cost is a permanent opening. The circuit does not close behind you. It stays answered.' She meets your eyes. 'That is not the same as dying. It is a different thing than dying. I wanted you to know that before the bridge, because the bridge will know what I have just told you, and it will know whether you knew it when you stepped onto it.'

» Walk in silence and let the information settle — arrive at the bridge with a clear body, not a working mind

You walk. You do not think — or rather, you do what the form taught you to do with an overloaded mind: you put it in the body and let the body carry it. The third text is inside your coat. The margin-note is inside the third text. The permanent opening is inside Davan's words, which are inside the morning air, which is inside your lungs on the four-count. You let it all sit where it sits. You do not arrange it.

Orrath and Davan seem to understand. They do not speak. The three of you fall into the same pace without discussing it — the pace of people who have long walks in their history, who know that a working mind arriving at

something difficult is worse than an empty one. The Fault-scars widen as you walk. The warmth through your boot-soles goes from occasional to constant, a low steady reminder that the ground beneath the King's Road is no longer entirely interested in being ground. The Shard tracks it the way it tracked the spear-tip in the Undyed Cloth's yard — a faint attentiveness, not alarm, just noting. You note it noting. You breathe.

The river announces itself before you see it: a quality of air, cooler and heavier, and beneath the coolness something else — the harmonic Davan described, low enough to feel in the sternum rather than hear in the ear. The Shard responds to it the way a struck bell responds to another struck bell in the same key: a sympathetic resonance, small and unmistakable. You do not name what this means. You breathe through it.

Then the road bends and the Greyveil bridge is in front of you. Stone, old stone, broad enough for two wagons abreast — or what was stone. The shape is entirely correct. The colour is almost correct. But the surface of it moves, very slowly, the way the surface of deep water moves when something large is breathing beneath it, and the joints between the paving stones glow with the same amber light as the widest Fault-scars on the road, except here they are not seams. They are veins. The bridge is not stone anymore. It is stone that has been listening for six months and has become something that listens. On the far side, fifty feet away through air that has the quality of a held breath, the road continues west,

perfectly ordinary, as if none of this is happening. The bridge waits. It has been waiting. It knows you are here — you feel it register you the moment the road bends, the way a sleeping person registers a candle brought close without waking. Davan stops one pace behind you and to your left. Orrath stops at your right. Neither speaks. The question of what to do belongs entirely to you.

» Step onto the first stone deliberately, weight evenly placed, spear across your back — arrive as a body, not a concept, and answer what comes

You step onto the first stone.

Not as a man who carries a Shard. Not as a vessel, a key, an answer, a exile, a spear-master. You step as a body: heel, arch, toe, weight distributed the way the Crane-in-Storm root stance distributes weight — nothing held back, nothing braced against what is coming. The four-count breath. The sternum open.

The bridge reads you immediately. Not like a gate reads a document — more like water reads a hand placed in it, every surface at once, all the information given simultaneously. You feel it the way you felt the Fault-scar warmth through your boot-soles on the road, but concentrated, precise, a full attention turned on you from below. The amber light in the veins brightens slightly under your foot and then stills, as if something leaned close to look and then settled back, satisfied that you are exactly what you appeared to be from a distance. The bridge's surface continues its slow breathing motion

and your body moves with it, not because you choose to but because your body is a body and knows instinctively how to stand on ground that breathes: you let your knees stay soft. You breathe with it. You do not perform willingness. You simply do not withhold.

The question comes at the middle of the bridge, at the point where the amber veins converge into a single line running exactly down the center of the span. It does not come as words. It comes as a direct address — the way you know a silence is addressed to you and not the room. The question is this: *what are you, now, that you were not before you began carrying it?* Not who. Not whether. What. You do not think. You let the body answer from what it knows, from seventeen years of carrying it through exile without understanding it, from the Crane-in-Storm form that was built around it before you were told it was there, from the failed reach in Orrath's courtyard, from the warmth tracking the spear-tip, from the word utharvel, from Davan's permanent opening, from standing in the Undyed Cloth's narrow yard at dawn and knowing the spear was the one thing that belonged entirely to you — and from knowing, this morning, that this was no longer precisely true. What you answer, from the body, without language: *a third thing. Not the man who arrived carrying it unknowing. Not the Shard. A third thing, still becoming, not yet named.*

The amber light under your feet runs outward from the center-line in both directions like breath released. The bridge's surface stills — not stopped, not dead, but

resting, the deep breathing replaced by something quieter and more voluntary, the quality of something that has heard what it needed to hear and does not need to hold you any further. You walk the remaining twenty feet to the far bank and step off onto ordinary road-stone without ceremony. The air on the north side of the river is cooler and entirely itself. Behind you, after a moment, you hear Davan's step on the first stone — unhurried, practiced, the tread of someone who has done this before and knows what it costs and pays it cleanly.

» Wait on the north bank in silence until Orrath and Davan have both crossed, then continue without comment

You stand on the north bank in the cool air and wait. Not watching the bridge with the attention of someone expecting it to fail — watching it the way you watch a student in a form, present but not intervening. The amber veins are quieter now, a slower pulse, the bridge returned to something closer to rest than it has probably been in weeks. Davan crosses in the way she described: fully present, unhurried, her weight meeting each stone as a complete transaction. At the center-line the light brightens briefly under her feet — recognition, not challenge — and then she steps off onto the north bank without a word or a changed expression. She has done this before. It shows.

Orrath takes longer at the threshold's edge. He stands there for nearly a full minute, and you do not look at him directly, because a man earning his footing on something that reads intention does not need to be

watched while he does it. When he crosses, he crosses slowly, both hands open at his sides, and at the center-line he stops — one full breath held, then released — and the bridge accepts him with the same quiet brightening it gave Davan. He steps off onto the north bank and stands beside you and does not speak.

The three of you stand on ordinary road-stone for a moment. The Fault harmonic is still in the air behind you, the bridge still breathing its slow breath over the dark water. The Shard in your sternum has gone quiet — not absent, not withdrawn, but the attentiveness has settled into something lower and steadier, the way a held note resolves into the chord it was always part of. Ahead, the King's Road runs west through scrub and pale rock toward the foothills, and somewhere three miles past the foothills, the Thornheel staging camp holds four shrine-components and a Conclave checkpoint and a geometry that has twenty-two days before it opens without an answer. You shoulder the spear and walk.

» Check the route-map and assess how many days remain to the Auric Mountains proper

You pull the route-map from inside your coat without breaking stride, unrolling it against your forearm the way you would read terrain notes in the field — economy of motion, eyes moving between the paper and the road ahead. The cartographer's work is clean: distances marked in half-day increments, elevations noted in a cramped hand along the mountain's western approach, the Greyveil crossing marked with a small symbol you

now understand differently than she intended it.

You are here, just north of the river. The Thornheel staging camp sits at the foothills' first rise, the cartographer's mark reading three miles past the crossing — less than two hours at your current pace, which means you will reach the Conclave checkpoint before midday. Past Thornheel, the King's Road narrows and climbs. The Auric Mountains proper begin where the road ends, at a place marked only as the High Approach — the cartographer's notation says 'road unsuitable past this point; guides recommended.' From Thornheel to the High Approach: half a day on good footing, more if the Fault-scarring has reached the mountain paths, which it probably has. From the High Approach to the Wellspring's deep site beneath the peaks: the map does not say. The map was not built for this.

You do the arithmetic against Vaun's number: twenty-two days until the geometric window opens. The walk from Veranthos is done. You have perhaps three hours before you are standing in front of a Conclave checkpoint at Thornheel with a spear, two Thornwood shamans, and a Shard of Prior Covenant behind your sternum. The staging camp beyond that checkpoint holds four assembled shrine-components and, presumably, Conclave wardens who have been told to turn back everything that is not Sealer blue-threadwork. The map tells you the rest of the road clearly. The map does not tell you what you are going to say at the checkpoint, or whether the Conclave's astronomers have already

begun moving components toward the Wellspring's lower approach.

You roll the map and tuck it back inside your coat. Orrath walks on your left. Davan on your right. Ahead, the foothills are visible now — pale stone and winter scrub rising against a sky that carries, at its westward edge, the faintest quality of voreth. Something before it decides what it is.

» Walk straight through the checkpoint — foreigner, spear, no manifest, no apology; answer only what is directly asked

The Thornheel checkpoint resolves itself out of the road ahead with the mundane clarity of a thing that has been waiting: two wardens in blue threadwork standing either side of a rope-and-post barrier, a third sitting on a folding stool with a ledger, the whole arrangement planted three miles into the foothills at a widening in the King's Road where the scrub thins and the pale rock of the mountain's first rise begins to show. Behind them, fifty yards further up the slope, you can see the edge of the staging camp — canvas and crates and the faint blue light of Conclave lantern-work. Four shrine-components. The geometry's other pieces, assembled and waiting.

You do not slow your pace. You walk straight to the rope. The warden with the ledger stands, and the two flanking wardens register the spear across your back with the specific attention of people trained to register exactly that. The ledger-warden is young, serious, and not frightened — which means he has been in this posting

long enough to have developed a procedure and not long enough to have had the procedure fail him. He asks, in Avelornian, what your business is on the King's Road west. You answer in trade-tongue, evenly: 'The mountains.' He switches to trade-tongue without hesitation — trained for this border, then — and asks whether you carry components under Conclave authorization. 'No.' He asks your origin. 'The east.' He looks at Orrath and Davan behind you, at their hill-country clothing, at the spear, and then he looks back at you, and you can see him running the arithmetic of whether you are worth the trouble of turning back. His flanking wardens have not moved to the rope, which means they have not decided to stop you. They are waiting for him to decide.

You meet his eyes and say nothing further. The silence is not hostile. It is the silence of a man who has answered every question he was asked and considers the transaction complete. The ledger-warden holds the silence for three full seconds — trying to find the question that produces a problem, and finding that each question he could ask would receive a clean answer that gives him nothing actionable. A foreigner. A spear. Two Thornwood. The mountain. All of it true. None of it forbidden by the orders he is carrying, which were written to stop unauthorized components and Quietist agitators, neither of which you have declared yourself to be. He makes a note in his ledger — you watch his pen move without being able to read what it says — and then he lifts the rope. 'Stay off the staging camp perimeter,'

he says. You walk through. Orrath and Davan follow. Behind you, the rope drops back into place.

» Keep moving — pass the staging camp without stopping and push for the High Approach before the Conclave registers you as anything other than a footnote in a ledger

You do not look at the staging camp. Looking at it would make it a destination. You walk past it the way you walk past a warden post in a city where you have legitimate business elsewhere — eyes ahead, pace unchanged, the spear across your back a fact rather than a threat. The camp is canvas and crates and the blue-white light of Conclave lantern-work, three or four scholars moving between tents with the focused distraction of people working a problem under time pressure. One of them looks up as you pass the perimeter. You are already past him before he has finished looking.

Orrath and Davan walk. They do not look at the camp either. The three of you are a simple fact on the road: people moving uphill toward the mountain, which is the direction the road goes.

The King's Road narrows above Thornheel, exactly as the cartographer noted. The pale rock of the first rise closes in on either side, and the scrub gives way to lichen and loose stone and the occasional winter-stripped elder clinging to a crack in the slope. The Fault-scars here are different from the road-level ones — not amber seams in paving stone but faint luminous breath rising from the rock itself, the mountain exhaling warmth

through its own skin. The Shard notices. You breathe through it.

You are perhaps twenty minutes above the staging camp, the canvas and lanterns already below and behind, when you reach the cartographer's note made real: the road ends. Not dramatically — it simply becomes less road and more intention, the cut stone giving way to packed earth giving way to bare rock, a faint trail of boot-marks and old cairns continuing upward toward where the peaks begin in earnest. The High Approach. Above it, the Auric Mountains proper, pale and enormous against a sky that carries voreth at its western edge — that undecided colour, bleeding down from the peaks as if the mountains themselves are the source of it. Davan stops beside you and looks up without speaking. The air here has weight and a low harmonic that is no longer just in the boot-soles but in the chest, in the sternum, in the specific place where the Shard sits. It is not alarm. It is recognition. The mountain knows you are here, the way the bridge knew — not the same reading, deeper, older, the attention of something that has been waiting longer than the bridge has been stone.

Turning point: Standing at the High Approach where the King's Road dissolves into bare rock and old cairns, with the Auric Mountains rising against a sky bleeding voreth, the Shard resonates in deep recognition — and the mountain, older and vastly more patient than the bridge, registers your arrival. The chapter closes not on a gate or a guard or a choice, but on the moment the mountain turns its attention

toward the one thing that has crossed a Fault-threshold and answered honestly: a third thing, still becoming, carrying twenty-two days and a word that means answer.

Chapter 4

» Say nothing and look to Orrath and Davan — let them indicate whether this threshold is theirs to read first

You look to them without speaking. Not deference — consultation. The gesture of a man who knows what he carries and also knows what he does not know, and has learned to hold both without embarrassment.

Orrath reads the look immediately. He steps forward, not past you but beside you, and tilts his head back to read the slope the way he read the Shard in the Undyed Cloth's yard — the same quality of attention, the same refusal to hurry the information. The voreth-light bleeds down from the peaks in slow pulses, and the Fault-harmonic in the chest is louder here, a frequency that sits just below deliberate thought and shapes it anyway. Orrath stands in it for a long moment. Then he says: 'The mountain is not asking yet. It is counting.' He pauses. 'Three presences. It is counting them. When it is satisfied with the count it will ask something.' He does not say what.

Davan has moved to the left of the path, where a Fault-scar runs up through exposed rock in a wide amber vein — broader than anything on the King's Road below, the width of a man's palm. She crouches and holds her open hand above it without touching, not quite reading, listening in the way she described at the Greyveil

crossing: fully present, not pushing a question back. After a silence she says, in her rough-edged trade-tongue: 'The last people who came to this threshold came with components and authority and a mandate from the Conclave. The mountain counted them and found them carrying a question it had already been asked.' A pause. 'It turned them back.' She stands and looks at you — not at your sternum this time, but at your face. 'You are carrying something it has not been asked before. It is deciding whether that is a reason to open or a reason to be very careful.' She says the last words without alarm, as simple information. 'Let it finish counting. Do not reach toward it yet. That is my reading.' She steps back to the path. Orrath nods once — the nod of a man confirming that two independent readings arrived at the same result. The three of you stand at the High Approach in the voreth-light, the mountain counting its presences, the Shard warm and attentive and saying nothing, the peaks enormous and undecided above you.

» Stand completely still and let the mountain finish its count without interference — full presence, nothing withheld, nothing offered yet

You stand completely still.

Not the stillness of a man waiting for something to be over — the stillness of the Crane-in-Storm root stance held at its deepest point, where the body has exhausted every unnecessary thing and what remains is simply what is. Feet on the bare rock of the High Approach. Spear across your back. Coat moving slightly in the

mountain air. Breath on the four-count, anchored at the sternum where the Shard sits warm and unhurried, neither reaching nor withdrawing. Nothing withheld. Nothing offered. Full presence, which is its own kind of answer to a question that has not yet been asked.

The mountain counts.

You feel it the way you felt the bridge read you — all surfaces at once, simultaneous — but slower, deeper, the attention of something that has been doing this for an enormous duration and does not need to hurry. It reads Orrath first, or perhaps it reads him last, or perhaps it reads all three of you in the same moment and what you are perceiving as sequence is only the order in which your body registers each note of a chord already struck. Orrath on your left does not move. Davan on your right does not move. The voreth-light pulses once from the peaks above — a long slow exhale of that undecided colour — and the Fault-harmonic in your chest shifts frequency, drops, resolves into something lower and steadier, the way the bridge's breathing stilled when you answered it.

The count finishes.

The silence that follows is not empty. It is the silence of something that has completed one action and has not yet begun the next — a breath held between exhale and inhale, a stance between two forms. You feel the

mountain's attention settle on your sternum with a precision that makes the bridge's reading feel like a glance. This is not a threshold checking passage. This is something older asking whether you know what you are carrying and whether you know what carrying it has cost and whether, knowing both, you are still here. Not a question yet. An orientation — the mountain pointing itself at you before it decides what to ask. The Shard responds from inside your chest with a warmth that is not heat exactly but presence, the way the struck bell responds to its matching frequency: I am here. I have always been here. I know what I am.

Orrath says, very quietly, without moving: 'It has finished counting.' A pause. 'It knows what you are.' Another pause, longer. 'It is deciding whether to ask you or tell you.'

» Say aloud, in Zhennian, to the mountain: that you came to witness, not to offer, and ask it to begin

You speak aloud, in Zhennian, for the first time since leaving the east.

The words are not loud. They do not need to be. The mountain's attention is already on your sternum and the language it hears is not the sounds but the fact beneath the sounds — a Zhennian spear-master's precise, economical Zhennian, the language of the man who existed before the Shard, before the exile, before the utharvel that made him a third thing — and in choosing this language you are offering the mountain something

you have not offered any threshold: the original shape, the first person, the one who received the Shard without being asked and carried it without understanding it for seventeen years. You say: *I came to witness. Not to offer. Begin.*

The voreth-light stops pulsing.

What replaces it is not light and not dark but the quality Orrath described — the colour of a thing before it decides what it is, except now it is not at the edges of the sky but in the air directly in front of you, at the point where the High Approach meets the mountain's first bare rock, and it is not small. The Fault-harmonic in your chest drops to a frequency below breathing, below thought, below the deepest root of the Crane-in-Storm stance, and sits there like the fundamental note of a chord so large you have only been hearing its overtones until now. The Shard does not pulse or brighten. It opens — not outward, but inward, the way a door opens inward, and what comes through is not a vision or a voice but a transmission of the kind the courtyard reach failed to hold: vast, and turning, and interior, and old beyond the word old, and present in the way that only things which have had no one to be present *to* for a very long time are present when the absence finally ends. It is dreaming. It has been dreaming. The refused shapes — all the forms the Archmages would not allow — move in it the way weather moves in a country too large to see from any single point. And underneath the

dreaming, clear and unmistakable, the thing Davan called the permanent opening, the thing Orrath called the question the Unsutured have held for eleven years, the thing your teacher hid in a margin in characters smaller than ornamentation:

An attentiveness. Aimed at you. The Wellspring has been waiting for the direction of travel to reverse — for something it was taken from to come back carrying it. It does not speak. It does not ask. It simply opens its count of what you are and waits, in the way of something that has learned, over a thousand years of dreaming, the difference between being witnessed and being used.

Behind you, very quietly, Orrath makes a sound you have not heard from him before. Not surprise. Recognition, of the kind that hurts.

The voreth-field holds you in its light. The mountain is not blocking passage. It is offering it. The path upward is open.

...to be continued.

Dramatis Personae

Ming (you) — Exiled Far-Eastern Spear Master

Strength 14 · Agility 16 · Wits 12 · Arcane 6 · Resolve 12

Last seen: overwhelmed

Dav Soot — Veranthos street courier and opportunist

Strength 9 · Agility 15 · Wits 13 · Arcane 4 · Resolve 8

Last seen: nervous

Disposition toward you: 10

Orrath the Unsutured — Thornwood war-band scout

Strength 15 · Agility 14 · Wits 11 · Arcane 10 · Resolve 13

Last seen: calm

Disposition toward you: 10

Serevaine — Grey-faction operative — claims connection to Ming's teacher

Strength 8 · Agility 10 · Wits 17 · Arcane 14 · Resolve 15

Last seen: controlled

Disposition toward you: 10

Thessaly Vorn — Archmagister of the Conclave Sealers

Strength 7 · Agility 9 · Wits 17 · Arcane 18 · Resolve 14

Last seen: urgent

Disposition toward you: 5

Davan — Thornwood Unsutured shaman, travelling companion

Strength 10 · Agility 13 · Wits 14 · Arcane 15 · Resolve 13

Last seen: calm

Disposition toward you: 47

**Orrath the Unsutured — Thornwood shaman,
elder of the Unsutured band in Veranthos**

Strength 7 · Agility 9 · Wits 16 · Arcane 14 · Resolve 15

Last seen: watchful and composed

Disposition toward you: 20

**Orrath — Elder shaman of the Thornwood
Unsutured**

Strength 8 · Agility 9 · Wits 16 · Arcane 14 · Resolve 15

Last seen: tense

Disposition toward you: 55

**Edric Vaun — Reassigned Conclave scholar,
formerly geometry-text analyst**

Strength 7 · Agility 8 · Wits 14 · Arcane 11 · Resolve 8

Last seen: exhausted and cornered

Disposition toward you: 20

Edric Vaun — Reassigned Conclave scholar

Strength 7 · Agility 8 · Wits 14 · Arcane 13 · Resolve 8

Last seen: defeated and quietly frightened

Disposition toward you: 5